the SPDC, which until recently had a near zero-tolerance policy on political dissent. Censorship, human rights violations, persecution of ethnic and religious minorities, and suppression of individual liberties is commonplace. The position of prime minister is appointed by the SPDC, solidifying the monopolization of power.

The current constitution was last amended in 1974. The junta claims that steps are being taken to fundamentally change the structure and function of the government. A first step in this process was the holding of a referendum in May 2008. This was followed in 2010 by the first democratically held elections in two decades. The process was seriously flawed, with stipulations in place to ensure military dominance over the process and future governing structure.

EDUCATION

Education is required for students age 5 through 10. An examination system is required to qualify for secondary schooling. Less than half of the students in Myanmar qualify for the next level. Even though a significant percentage of students do not advance, literacy rates in Myanmar are nearly 90 percent. Education is thus highly valued in the culture of Myanmar.

Religious institutions, including monasteries, accomplish an essential part of the educational system in Myanmar. Buddhist instruction is emphasized in addition to basic rudimentary skills such as reading, writing, and math. English is widely used in schooling throughout Myanmar. As the junta tries to modernize and integrate with the outside world, the importance of English has become a reality.